



Sam Houston
State University

2026 -
2027

HANDBOOK

COM Student Handbook



Sam Houston State University
Graduate & Professional School

TABLE OF CONTENTS

TABLE OF CONTENTS	1
MESSAGE FROM SHSU ACADEMIC AFFAIRS	4
WELCOME	5
SHSU-COM Mission	5
SHSU-COM Goals.....	5
SHSU-COM Objectives.....	5
SHSU-COM PROGRAM OVERVIEW	6
Accreditation.....	6
General Information.....	7
Clerkship	9
FACULTY & STAFF	10
SHSU-COM CURRICULA.....	11
Foundational Competencies for Undergraduate Medical Education	11
Attendance Policy	13
Leave of Absence	14
Grading Policies.....	17
Examination Procedures and Policies	18
Test Administration	19
Promotion, Remediation, Probation, Graduation, and Dismissal	24
Academic Honor Code.....	28
Academic Standing	28
COMLEX-USA Examinations.....	29

Student-Provided Technological Devices	30
Graduation Requirements	31
Resignation From the Program	31
RESEARCH & TRAVEL	32
Student Research Eligibility	32
Research Ethics and Compliance.....	32
Research Funding.....	33
Student Travel and Travel Funding.....	33
STUDENT SERVICES & RESOURCES	35
Physical and Mental Health Resources	35
Academic Resources and Support	36
Financial Aid and Debt Management	37
Newton Gresham Library	38
Student Organizations	38
Reasonable Accommodations and Disability Services	39
Student Travel, Contingency Plan, and Housing	40
Behavioral Intervention Team (BIT).....	40
ACADEMIC STANDARDS & STUDENT DEVELOPMENT	41
Professionalism	41
Immunization Requirements	42
Background Checks and Drug Testing.....	44
Health Insurance	45
Needle Stick/Exposure.....	46
Summer Preceptor Guidelines	47
Malpractice Insurance Coverage Policy	47

Dress Code	47
Course and Faculty Evaluations.....	48
Participation	49
Reproduction of Materials	49
Compliance and Training.....	49
SHSU ACADEMIC REQUIREMENTS AND POLICIES	51
Academic Good Standing	51
Academic Grievance Procedures for Students.....	51
Academic Honesty	51
Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination.....	51
Course Load	51
Courses and Grades Applied to Degrees and Certificates	51
Graduate Academic Program Admission and Completion Requirements	51
Leave of Absence.....	51
Resignation	51
Student Code of Conduct.....	51
Student Grievance Procedures	51
Student Absences on Religious Holy Days.....	52
Students with Disabilities	52
Title IX and Discrimination	52
Student Privacy Information (FERPA)	52

MESSAGE FROM SHSU ACADEMIC AFFAIRS

The *Sam Houston State University College of Osteopathic Medicine Student Handbook* outlines the AY 2026-2027 policies and procedures for all SHSU-COM students and supersedes previously published handbooks.

The provisions of this handbook do not constitute a contract, expressed or implied, between any applicant, student, faculty member, or staff employee and Sam Houston State University, including the College of Osteopathic Medicine, or the Texas State University System. In the event of a conflict between the provisions of this handbook and the Texas State University System Rules and Regulations (<https://www.tsus.edu/about-tsus/policies.html>), the latter shall govern.

University-wide policies can be found in the last section of this handbook. Additional information can be found in the current graduate and professional catalog <http://shsu.edu/academics/catalog/>, Sam Houston State University's Academic Policy Manual <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/policies.html>, and on the [Dean of Students' Office](#) website.

WELCOME

SHSU-COM Mission

The mission of the Sam Houston State University (SHSU) College of Osteopathic Medicine (SHSU-COM) is to prepare students for the degree of Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine with an emphasis toward primary care and rural practice, to develop culturally aware and compassionate physicians, who follow osteopathic principles, that are prepared for graduate medical education and will serve the people of Texas with professionalism and patient-centered care.

A significant part of the mission of the COM is to increase the physician workforce in the eastern region of Texas and to increase access to primary care. The COM will accomplish this by recruiting qualified applicants from areas to which they would likely want to return and establish their practice.

SHSU-COM Goals

The goals of SHSU-COM are to:

- Recruit candidates nationally, while targeting underserved communities in the SHSU-COM service region.
- Include qualified candidates from underrepresented populations with a focus on East Texas in the selection pool.
- Demonstrate academic excellence.
- Develop an orientation toward primary care and service to the community.
- Instill a need for life-long learning.
- Imprint the philosophy of holistic care of the individual and the principles of osteopathic practice.
- Prepare students for graduation and residency training.

SHSU-COM Objectives

The objectives of SHSU-COM are to:

- Provide an excellent academic experience based on early clinical training and an integrated curriculum taught by highly skilled and experienced lecturers and clinicians.
- Reinforce the quality of the academic experience through biomedical and clinical research.
- Collaborate with SHSU faculty wherever possible.
- Create opportunities with clinical and community partners.
- Facilitate the success of our students through recognition of their achievements and preparation for GME.

SHSU-COM PROGRAM OVERVIEW

Accreditation

Process and Approval

SHSU-COM has been approved to recruit, matriculate, teach, and graduate students in the Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine (DO) program by the following entities:

- The Commission on Osteopathic College Accreditation (COCA) – the American Osteopathic Association’s (AOA) accreditation body as codified in 34 CFR §602, ensuring that all COMs have met or exceeded the Commission’s Standards for educational quality;
- The Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Commission on Colleges (SACSCOC) – the regional body for the accreditation of degree-granting higher education institutions in the Southern states; and the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board – a Texas agency that oversees all public post-secondary education in the state.

The College was codified through Texas House Bill 2867 (effective March 29, 2019), which allows access to residency funding and other resources relevant to Texas medical schools. Texas Senate Bill 1563 was passed by the legislature and signed by the governor on May 19, 2023, providing the college access to formula funding.

For more information regarding SHSU-COM’s accreditation status, please visit <https://www.shsu.edu/academics/colleges/osteopathic-medicine/about/history-and-accreditation>. For more information regarding COCA accreditation, please visit <https://osteopathic.org/accreditation/>.

Policy on Student Complaints Regarding Institutional Compliance with Accreditation Standards

The Dean of the SHSU-COM, or other designated COM officials, will address expressed, informal concerns of students regarding institutional compliance in accordance with current COCA COM Continuing Accreditation Standards. If the complaints are determined to have merit, the Dean or designated institutional official will institute any required changes in institutional policy or procedures to bring the SHSU-COM into compliance with COCA accreditation standards and COCA policies and procedures. Formal complaints filed through the COCA Secretary will be in accordance with COCA Accreditation Standards and COCA Policies and Procedures. All records of the proceedings regarding receipt, adjudication, and resolution of student formal and informal complaints in these matters will be maintained in the Office of the Dean.

Students' Rights and Responsibilities in Reviewing Standards and Policies of Accreditation

Students have the right to review the standards and policies for accreditation of the institution as published by the COCA. Copies of accreditation standards and procedures are available online through the Office of Assessment, Evaluation, and Accreditation of SHSU-COM. Individual students or their class representatives may register formal or informal concerns or complaints regarding the compliance of the institution with accreditation standards or procedures as published by the COCA. Informal concerns should be addressed to the Dean of the SHSU-COM, preferably in writing. Formal concerns or complaints should be filed in accordance with the policies and procedures of the COCA described in *Accreditation of Colleges of Osteopathic Medicine: COM Policies and Procedures*. These concerns must be in writing, signed, and should be submitted directly to the COCA by contacting the American Osteopathic Association (AOA)/ Commission on Osteopathic College Accreditation (COCA), 142 E. Ontario St., Chicago, IL 60611, at predoc@osteopathic.org or (312) 202-8174. The COCA Policies and Procedures may be found at: <https://osteopathic.org/accreditation/standards/>.

General Information

SHSU-COM Honor Code

The SHSU-COM Honor Code will be developed by students as a set of ethical principles governing the SHSU-COM community based on ideals that define what constitutes honorable behavior within the SHSU-COM community.

Students are expected to maintain good moral character throughout their medical school career by adhering to the ethical and professionalism standards set forth in this handbook.

Student Code of Conduct

The SHSU Student Code of Conduct applies to SHSU-COM students and may be found here: <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/dean-of-students/student-code-of-conduct#> To submit an incident report visit [shsu.edu/doso](https://www.shsu.edu/doso).

Please note that those issues related to academic honesty, as defined in paragraph 5.3, Chapter VI, of The Texas State University System *Rules and Regulations* and SHSU Academic Policy Statement 810213 Academic Honesty, may be handled as a professionalism competency concern and referred to the COM Student Promotions and Academic Progress (SPAP) committee and governed by SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination.

Academic Calendar

Students should reference the published SHSU-COM academic calendar for an overview of the academic year and important dates and deadlines. Students should reference Blackboard for details regarding specific course and clerkship events.

Holidays

For pre-clerkship years, students should reference the SHSU-COM academic calendar for designated holidays and applicable SHSU policies for religious holy days. Attendance requirements on clinical services during religious or national holidays are at the discretion of the preceptor and/or training facility in compliance with federal law.

Vacations and Breaks

For pre-clerkship years, students should reference the SHSU-COM academic calendar for designated breaks. Pre-clerkship SHSU-COM breaks do not apply to clerkship years. Students are assigned four (4) weeks of vacation during their fourth-year clerkships. Please refer to the clerkship manual for specific guidelines and limitations regarding the allotted vacation time.

Emergency Preparedness

In the case of an emergency, important information can be found through [KatSafe](#). To increase the success of the [KatSafe](#) notification system, it is important to keep all contact information current.

Inclement Weather

The SHSU-COM is committed to the safety and security of its students, faculty, staff, and visitors. At times, severe weather may result in closures to SHSU facilities, roads, and services. When the campus is impacted due to inclement weather, notification will be sent to students directly from [KatSafe](#), the emergency notification system.

Unless scheduled to be on campus, students participating in clerkship rotations are to follow the instructions of their preceptor at their designated clerkship rotation site with regard to inclement weather.

Grievances

See Academic Policy 900823, Academic Grievance Procedures for Students (<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/students/900823%20Academic%20Grievance%20Procedures%20for%20Students.pdf>).

To file an academic or nonacademic grievance, visit
<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/grievances.html>.

If the complaint involves discrimination or sexual misconduct, SHSU recommends that you report your complaint as provided in the SHSU Nondiscrimination Policy https://www.shsu.edu/institutional-transparency/policy/administrative/pre-29-non-discrimination-policy.pdf?utm_source=slash-titleix&utm_medium=slash-titleix&utm_campaign=slash-titleix and/or the TSUS Sexual Misconduct Policy and Procedures https://www.shsu.edu/institutional-transparency/policy/fo-title-ix/sexual-misconduct-policy-08-12-22.pdf?utm_source=slash-titleix&utm_medium=slash-titleix&utm_campaign=slash-titleix available here: <https://www.shsu.edu/titleix/>.

If there is an immediate threat to health and/or safety or you require emergency assistance, please contact University Police at 936-294-1800 or dial 911.

Clerkship

Students in years 3 and 4 should refer to the SHSU-COM Clerkship Manual for additional policies, procedures, and resources.

FACULTY & STAFF

Faculty and Staff Directory

The SHSU-COM faculty and staff directory may be accessed at:
<https://www.shsu.edu/academics/colleges/osteopathic-medicine/people>

Faculty-Student Research Collaboration Opportunities

Information including research bios, certifications and expertise, and scholarly highlights are available through the Newton Gresham Library “Scholarship @ SHSU-COM” which may be accessed at:
<https://shslibraryguides.org/c.php?g=1077324&p=8064559>

COM research programs and activities as well as research highlights may be reviewed at: <https://www.shsu.edu/academics/colleges/osteopathic-medicine/research/>

Faculty-Student Relations

Learning Communities (<https://www.shsu.edu/academics/colleges/osteopathic-medicine/student-life-support/learning-communities-student-organizations>) offer peer, faculty, and staff mentoring opportunities. In addition, participation in student organizations enables students to work with and collaborate with faculty and staff. Students also receive a faculty advisor who helps provide individualized coaching and advising throughout their medical school experience.

Foundational Competencies for Undergraduate Medical Education

The *Foundational Competencies for Undergraduate Medical Education*, as prepared by the American Association of Colleges of Osteopathic Medicine in conjunction with the Association of American Medical Colleges and Accreditation Council for Graduate Medical Education, include:

- I. Professionalism
- II. Patient Care and Procedural Skills
- III. Medical Knowledge
- IV. Practice-Based Learning and Improvement
- V. Interpersonal and Communication Skills
- VI. Systems-Based Practice

Detailed descriptions of each, including osteopathic principles and tenets and DO-specific sub-competencies, may be found at https://www.aacom.org/docs/default-source/initiatives/foundational_competencies.pdf.

Responsibilities and Technical Standards

Responsibilities

An osteopathic physician must have the knowledge and skills to function in a broad variety of clinical situations and to render a wide spectrum of patient care. To perform the activities described below, candidates for the DO degree must be able to...

- quickly, accurately, and consistently learn, integrate, analyze, and synthesize data;
- facilitate the attainment of optimum care and safety;
- exhibit high moral and behavioral standards reflecting the position and status of an osteopathic physician; and
- demonstrate respect for individuals and groups irrespective of race, ethnicity, color, sex, sexual orientation, gender, gender identity, national origin, age or disabilities, and religion.

Non-Discrimination Policy

SHSU is committed to an educational and work environment that provides equal opportunity and access to all qualified persons. SHSU pursuant to and in accordance with applicable federal and state law (including Title VII and Title IX) and institutional values, prohibits discrimination or harassment on the basis of race, creed, ancestry, marital status,

citizenship, color, national origin, sex, religion, age, disability, veteran's status, hair texture/protected hairstyle, pregnancy, sexual orientation, gender identity, or gender expression in employment, educational programs, activities, and admissions. The SHSU PRE-29 - Non-Discrimination Policy may be found here:

<https://www.shsu.edu/institutional-transparency/policy/administrative/pre-29-non-discrimination-policy.pdf>

Each supervisor, faculty member, employee, and student is responsible for maintaining an environment that is free of discrimination and for addressing behaviors that violate this obligation in accordance with this policy.

Academic Credentials

To be considered for admission to any program offered by SHSU, a student must possess the academic credentials and professional attributes deemed essential by the respective program's admissions committee for selection to the program.

Technical Standards

Every student of SHSU-COM is expected to possess those intellectual, ethical, physical, and emotional capabilities required to undertake the full curriculum and to achieve the levels of competence required by the faculty. The SHSU-COM has adopted the following technical standards with due consideration for the safety and well-being of the patients cared for by its graduates, to include any reasonable accommodation for those with a qualifying disability as required by applicable state or federal law:

- **Observation and Visual Integration:** Students shall have sufficient visual capabilities to observe demonstrations, experiments, and laboratory exercises in the basic and clinical sciences, as well as proper evaluation and treatment integration to assess asymmetry, range of motion, and tissue color and texture changes.
- **Communication:** Students shall be able to speak, hear, and observe patients to elicit information, examine patients, describe changes in mood, activity and posture, and perceive nonverbal communication.
- **Motor Function:** Students shall have sufficient motor function to execute movements reasonably required to provide general care and emergency treatment to patients.
- **Strength and Mobility:** Students shall provide medical treatments, such as osteopathic manipulative medicine and cardiopulmonary resuscitation, which often require upright posture with sufficient upper and lower extremity and overall body strength and mobility.
- **Intellectual, Conceptual, Integrative and Quantitative Abilities:** Students shall be able to concentrate, analyze and interpret data, and make decisions within areas in which there is a reasonable amount of visual and auditory distraction. They must perform these functions under a time limitation and do so under a reasonable amount of stress.

- **Behavioral and Social Attributes:** Students shall possess the emotional health required for full utilization of their intellectual abilities, exercise good judgment, and promptly complete all responsibilities attendant to the diagnosis and care of patients with the ability to develop mature, sensitive, and effective professional relationships with patients.
- **Participation in Osteopathic Clinical Courses:** Active participation in Osteopathic Manipulative Medicine and Clinical Medicine skills training sessions are a requirement. During these sessions, it is imperative that students examine each other. This type of learning requires active participation where students observe, listen, and palpate, and will experience palpation by their peers and instructors of all genders to enhance the development of their own palpatory skills.
- **Availability:** Students shall have a dedication to the practice of Medicine such that they are available for instruction and preceptorship throughout the year to the full extent required under this handbook, SHSU policy, and applicable law.

Individuals who have significant limitations in these areas may require evaluation to determine if they are otherwise qualified and able to perform essential functions of the program, with or without reasonable accommodation.

Access the *Educational Council on Osteopathic Principles* document at: https://www.aacom.org/docs/default-source/publications/aacom-ecop-technical-standards-2009.pdf?sfvrsn=1d226197_0 for more information about technical standards.

Attendance Policy

The attendance policy helps define terminology and provides guidance for faculty, staff, and students where attendance is concerned. SHSU-COM encourages students to attend class, as there is a “moderate, positive correlation between the presence of psychosocial distress and the number of missed sessions” (Damant et al., 2016).¹

Osteopathic Medical Students (OMS), as future members of the profession at-large, are held to high levels of professionalism regarding items such as participation, engagement, scholarly activity, and service. The attendance policy reflects the professional culture of SHSU-COM.

Expectations

SHSU-COM faculty and staff expect that students attend all educational activities. Students should arrive on time and be prepared to receive instruction at the predetermined class start time.

¹ Damant, R., Rourke, L., Wilson, B., Lewis, M., Schutz, D., Harley, D., & Stobart, K. (2016). Medical school attendance is significantly lower in preclinical students who are experiencing psychological distress. *MedEdPublish*, 5(2). <https://doi.org/10.15694/mep.2016.000002>

Although not all educational activities are mandatory, many educational activities require the presence of all students to allow for the attainment of skills for active participation. Lack of participation could adversely affect the learning process of oneself and peers. As delineated in SHSU Academic Policy Statement 800401 (Class Attendance)

<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/800401%20Class%20Attendance.pdf>, SHSU-COM students should refer to this handbook for attendance guidance, which is as follows: Each course and clerkship shall refer students to the official SHSU-COM attendance policy, which shall be enforced by the Course or Clerkship Director.

Leave of Absence

A Leave of Absence (LOA) is an approved leave from SHSU-COM that postpones a student's course of academic and/or clerkship study. A LOA may not exceed one year. A student granted an LOA must complete the Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine (DO) degree not later than six (6) years following the student's date of matriculation at SHSU-COM (SHSU-COM Graduation Policy Statement <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/com-policies/SHSU-COM%20Graduation%20Policy%20Statement%20and%20Procedures.pdf>).

An LOA may be granted for military commitment, jury duty, pregnancy, maternity/paternity leave, or circumstances covered under the Family and Medical Leave Act of 1993. SHSU-COM refers pregnant and parenting students to the SHSU Office of Title IX (<https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/title-ix/know-your-nine/pregnant-parenting>) and SHSU PRE-31 – Pregnant & Parenting Students (<https://www.shsu.edu/institutional-transparency/policy/administrative/pre-31-pregnant-parenting-students-2025-7-10-25.pdf>). Students may also request or be placed on an LOA for personal, financial, or other special circumstances.

To return from an LOA, students shall, no later than 120 days before the next term begins, complete a return from LOA form. Students might also be asked to provide a medical attestation form from a treating physician or other healthcare provider who is not related to the student, stating the student is released to return and is able to meet the applicable Technical Standards of SHSU-COM. In cases of disability, the clearance letter must state if the student requires any accommodations upon their return. If so, the student shall be responsible for requesting such accommodations through the SHSU Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) Office. The Technical Standards subcommittee will also determine if the student is able to meet the Technical Standards of the SHSU-COM.

The Dean or their designee shall define in writing the terms and conditions of the LOA and the student's return to SHSU-COM. The Dean has the final authority to approve the LOA but may delegate this authority. The Dean or designee may consult with faculty and staff members before granting an LOA. A student's failure to comply with the conditions of their LOA is grounds for dismissal from the program.

Leave of Absence Request Process

Students may request a leave of absence (LOA) by completing and submitting the Leave of Absence Request Form and supporting documentation to Educational Affairs. Students should meet with the director of Medical Student Affairs to initiate this process.

Incomplete documents shall not be reviewed until all information has been received. The LOA request decision shall be provided via SHSU email within ten (10) business days from the date of receipt of the complete submission. Business days, as used in this handbook, shall mean Monday through Friday unless such a day has been recognized by SHSU as a holiday.

Before the LOA is approved, students are required to complete the checklist provided with the LOA form, which includes clearance from Financial Aid, the Registrar, and Student Affairs.

Types of Leave

Voluntary (Student-Initiated) Leave of Absence

A Voluntary (Student-Initiated) Leave of Absence (LOA) is a request by a student to discontinue coursework. An LOA may be granted for extenuating circumstances, which may include but are not limited to, military commitment, jury duty, or maternity/paternity leave. This type of leave is not to be utilized for deficiencies in academic progress and cannot be granted once the last final exam of a term is completed.

Personal Leave of Absence

A student in academic good standing may, at any time, request a Personal LOA for a specified period of time not to exceed one year. This type of LOA may be requested to take time for research, clinical work at another site without academic credit, or other types of academic enrichment.

Medical Leave of Absence

A student in academic good standing may request a Medical LOA. Students granted an LOA for medical reasons may be required to have a licensed physician, approved by the Dean, certify in writing that the student is able to resume their studies before returning to classes.

Parental Leave of Absence: Maternal, Paternal, Adoptive, etc.

Students may request Parental LOA to fulfill parental responsibilities. Please refer to the SHSU Office of Title IX (<https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/title-ix/know-your-nine/pregnant-parenting>) and SHSU PRE-31 – Pregnant & Parenting Students (<https://www.shsu.edu/institutional-transparency/policy/administrative/pre-31-pregnant-parenting-students-2025-7-10-25.pdf>)

Military Leave of Absence

Students called to active duty must notify the Office of Medical Student Affairs promptly and provide a copy of their orders for a Military LOA. Students who take leave under these circumstances may receive special consideration regarding obligations and requirements.

Mandatory (Administrative) Leave of Absence

A Mandatory (Administrative) Leave of Absence (LOA) is a LOA imposed by the Dean due to an identified reason. During an administrative leave, the student is required to follow the prescribed instructions and requirements associated with the leave and, if applicable, complete rehabilitation or treatment for the reason that precipitated the necessity for the leave.

Communication and Involvement with SHSU-COM During a Leave of Absence

- Students may lose access to SHSU resources or services (e.g., Blackboard).
- Students are required to monitor their school email, if active. If their school email is not active, students must provide an alternate email address.
- Students on LOA are required to communicate at least every two (2) months with the Office of Medical Student Affairs for the duration of the leave. This communication shall be initiated by the student and must occur during the first week of every other month, starting with the month following the onset of the leave.
- Students cannot be members of or serve in elected or leadership positions within student government or officially recognized student organizations.
- Students cannot participate in research activities with the COM.
- Students cannot serve as a representative of the COM.

Academic Standing and Return from Leave of Absence

If the Dean imposes an Administrative LOA or grants a Voluntary (Student-Initiated) LOA, and the student is in academic good standing, the student may resume the program at the end of the leave as indicated in the terms and conditions. Students must adhere to the terms and conditions provided in writing for the LOA.

If the Dean imposes an Administrative LOA or grants a Voluntary (Student-Initiated) LOA, and the student is not in good standing, is under review for a disciplinary action, or has a disciplinary action imposed on them, the student shall not resume the program without review by the SPAP Technical Standards Subcommittee. Upon completion of its review, the SPAP Technical Standards Subcommittee will make a recommendation to SPAP as to whether the student may resume the program.

Grading Policies

Final Grades

End-of-course or -clerkship grades are based upon academic performance, professional behavior, participation in class or clinical rotation, laboratory work, examinations, and other activities, as applicable to a course or clerkship rotation. In determining final grades, the proportionate weights assigned to graded components are determined by Course and Clerkship Directors. The basis upon which final grades are determined are stated in the syllabus at the start of each course and clerkship rotation.

Final Grade Appeals Process

The Course or Clerkship Director is the primary authority with respect to grades. A student wishing to appeal a final grade should first attempt to resolve the matter by meeting with the Course or Clerkship Director. Students not satisfied after attempting such resolution should follow the process outlined in this handbook.

Course Grades and Remediation

Course grades are determined according to methods outlined in course syllabi. Initial course grades are recorded by the SHSU Registrar as either “Honors” (H), “Pass” (P), or “Subject to Remediation” (SR), or “Fail” (F)

SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 (Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination (<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/910312%20Academic%20Probation%20and%20Suspension.pdf>) governs probation, suspension, dismissal, and termination of undergraduate and graduate students at SHSU. Students who are subject to remediation are automatically placed on probation. Course grades after remediation are replaced by the SHSU Registrar with either “Pass with Remediation” (PR) or “Fail” (F). Upon successful remediation, probation status is reviewed by the SPAP committee. Although a student may return to academic good standing and be removed from academic probation, the student’s transcript will continue to reflect the status of academic probation for the applicable term(s). Students who are not successful in remediation are reviewed by the SPAP committee to determine whether they are required to repeat the entire academic year or be

dismissed. Students repeating an academic year will have all passing grades (i.e., H, P, and PR) for all courses in the academic year replaced by the SHSU Registrar with “Pass, No Credit” (PN) prior to repeating the academic year. Student doctors who fail a clerkship retest will receive a “Fail” (F) on their transcript and remediate by repeating the clerkship. There is no “Pass with Remediation” (PR) status in the clinical years (Years 3 and 4).

At any point, a course grade may be recorded as “No Grade” (NG) or “Withdrawn” (W) according to procedures and definitions set forth by the SHSU Registrar.

Class Rank

For the SHSU-COM DO program, students shall be ranked after all pre-clerkship courses have been completed, including any remediation, and final grades assigned in Banner. Pre-clerkship courses have four (4) official final grades in Banner (Honors, Pass, Pass with Remediation, and Fail) plus an unofficial performance “state” (Pass with Retest, or Remediation #1). An average course performance (ACP) can be obtained by weighting individual course performance by course credit hours and then dividing the sum of weighted products by the number of pre-clerkship credit hours completed.

Through AY 2026-27, the following course performance points will be used:

- Honors = 4 points
- Pass = 3 points
- Pass with Retest (Remediation #1) = 2 points
- Pass with Remediation (Remediation #2) = 1 point
- Fail = 0 points

ACPs calculated after all pre-clerkship courses have been completed will be used to rank each cohort by quintiles. For example, the 1st quintile contains approximately 20% of the lowest performing students, and the 5th quintile contains approximately 20% of the highest performing students. No other class ranking distinction will be made for pre-clerkship course performance.

Final class quintiles will be disclosed to SHSU-COM students during Year 3, recorded by the SHSU Registrar, and may be indicated on transcripts and in Medical Student Performance Evaluations (MSPEs) for residency applications.

Examination Procedures and Policies

Examinations

Examinations shall take place at the date and time specified on the course or clerkship syllabus. Changes to the examination schedule are at the discretion of the Course or

Clerkship Director and shall be communicated to students in a timely fashion. All examinations are administered in accordance with the SHSU and SHSU-COM policies.

Missed Examinations

Students missing an examination should consult the official SHSU-COM attendance policy referenced in their syllabi.

Post-Examination Feedback and Review

Upon completion of an examination, students shall not communicate the content of any examination in any format (verbal, electronic, in writing) to any other student. Recording or sharing examination questions is considered academic dishonesty.

Students will not receive grades or other performance indicators at the time of the examination.

Summary information, such as psychometric analyses and individualized scores and strength-opportunity reports, shall be provided within a reasonable time after examinations. Post-examination reviews may be conducted at the discretion of Course or Clerkship Directors to provide aggregate performance information by discipline, topic, or objective, but shall not disclose specific examination questions.

Students who require remediation shall be afforded an opportunity to review their examination outcomes with a Learning Specialist to assess whether patterns of performance can be utilized to improve future performance.

A student's performance on clinical, performance, or practical examinations may be reviewed with a Learning Specialist or another faculty member at the discretion of the Course or Clerkship Director.

Test Administration

The SHSU-COM test administration policies and related procedures have been created to maintain a secure, standardized, and fair testing environment for all students. The policy applies to, but is not limited to, written examinations, practical examinations, Objective Structured Clinical Exams (OSCEs), Comprehensive Osteopathic Medical Achievement Test (COMAT) examinations taken during clerkship rotations, and licensing exam simulations.

Students are responsible for furnishing and maintaining any device required for an examination along with an approved privacy screen. Students must ensure that their device is updated and in good working order. All device functions, such as system updates, adequate storage, network connectivity, functioning audio/visual, and sufficient battery power, are the sole responsibility of the student. In cases of unexpected

technology issues or malfunctions during an exam, students may be given a loaner device. No additional time will be given as compensation for technology issues or malfunctions.

Students may receive additional instructions regarding examination devices from the Course or Clerkship Director, or from Educational Affairs.

Personal Belongings

- Students are provided with lockers to hold their personal belongings. Students are required to bring into the testing environment their SHSU-issued computer with its privacy screen, its charging device, and their SHSU ID. Students who arrive without the required materials will NOT be permitted to take the exam until 20 minutes after the scheduled start time. Students do not get to make up the 20 minutes of lost time.
- No other items shall be permitted in the immediate testing environment or on the person of the student. With the exception of the student's ID and approved items of medical necessity, all pockets, clothing compartments, and personal storage areas on the person must be empty prior to entering the testing environment and remain empty throughout the examination. Prohibited items may not be carried, stored, or concealed on the person, including in pockets, regardless of whether they are used during the examination.
- Prohibited items include, but are not limited to, cell phones, watches of any kind, smart-glasses (standard glasses may be subject to inspection), ear-buds, digital audio players, digital recorders, cameras, tablets, other similar electronic devices, calculators, pencils, pens, paper, notes, notebooks, notepads, books, reference materials, briefcases, backpacks, book bags, purses, wallets, caps, hats, scarves, blankets, keys, fobs, food, unsealed beverages (approved beverages must have a screw-top seal), and other related personal items. Entry with any of these items is considered academic dishonesty. Such conduct constitutes a serious violation of institutional policy and shall subject the student to the most severe disciplinary measures available, including, but not limited to, dismissal from the program. Exceptions may be granted on the basis of religious accommodation or illness.
- Dressing in layers is recommended; however, coats, hoodies, and jackets are discouraged and may be subject to inspection upon entry to the testing room.
- Course and Clerkship Directors may make special exceptions if a particular item (e.g., a calculator) is utilized during the examination.

Food and Drink

- Food is not permitted in the testing environment.
- Chewing gum is not allowed.
- A spill-proof drinking container, unwrapped cough drops or hard candy, and tissues are permitted.

Examination Time

- The testing room will be secured 60 minutes prior to the scheduled start time.
- Students may enter the testing room 20 minutes prior to the scheduled start time.
- Students are not permitted to exit the testing room after check-in without approval from the course director; this restriction remains in effect until the time when scheduled breaks are permitted.
- Students shall be in their seats and ready to start at least five (5) minutes prior to the scheduled start time.
- Access to the testing room will be restricted 2 minutes prior to the scheduled start time.
- Students who arrive after access to the testing room has been restricted will be subject to a 20-minute lockout penalty. No additional time will be given due to tardiness. Students who arrive later than 20 minutes after the scheduled start time will be considered absent. Students who are absent must follow the “Attendance Guidelines” section of this handbook.
- Students still testing with fewer than 5 minutes remaining in the exam will remain in their seat until the exam time has fully elapsed.
- Students requesting a break during an examination will be required to obtain the consent of a proctor or exam monitor and will be catalogued electronically or with a sign out sheet.
- All students must submit their examination by the scheduled stop time.
- Students may be required to show proof of submission to a proctor or exam monitor prior to leaving the testing room.
- Students are strictly prohibited from exiting the designated testing environment while in possession of any device on which an examination or quiz remains active or in progress. Any student who departs the testing room under such circumstances shall be deemed to have engaged in academic dishonesty. Such conduct constitutes a serious violation of institutional policy and shall subject the student to the most severe disciplinary measures available, including, but not limited to, dismissal from the program.

Attire

- Students are to wear the appropriate professional attire per the Student Handbook.

Examination Materials

- A whiteboard or paper and a pen may be provided for use during the examination.
- If a whiteboard or paper is provided, it must be returned at the end of the examination.

Talking

- Students may not talk in the testing environment during or after the examination.

Use of Restrooms and Exam Breaks

- The number of breaks permitted during an exam may be limited based on duration of exam:
 - Exams < 1 hour = 0 breaks;
 - Exams ≥ 1 hour and ≤ 2 hours = 1 break maximum;
 - Exams > 2 hours and ≤ 4 hours = 2 breaks maximum;
 - Exams > 4 hours = not to exceed 1 break per 2-hour session.
- No breaks permitted during the first 20 minutes and the last 20 minutes of exam.
- Breaks are expected to be less than 5 minutes; breaks exceeding 5 minutes may be checked by proctor.
- Students are expected not to exceed more than 5 exams with restroom breaks per semester; failure to comply may require proctor approval for additional breaks.
- The number of students permitted outside the testing room at the same time for a break may be limited.
- Students who need to use the restroom during the examination may be escorted by a faculty proctor.
- No additional time shall be added to the examination period to compensate for restroom breaks.
- Due to the special nature of practical examinations and OSCEs, restroom breaks are not allowed unless an accommodation has been provided through the SHSU SSD Office.
- Students should be aware that exam-related behaviors, including break frequency and duration, are monitored and recorded. Patterns that fall outside typical expectations may be reviewed as part of ongoing efforts to maintain academic integrity.
- Students whose exam activity reflects irregular, atypical, or elevated patterns, including but not limited to frequent or prolonged breaks, may be flagged for further review. Flagging does not constitute a violation in itself but may prompt additional oversight.
- Students identified for follow-up based on monitored behaviors may be subject to immediate and ongoing enhanced accountability measures during future exams. These measures may include, but are not limited to, additional proctor monitoring, reassigned seating, or modified break procedures, and are required conditions of continued exam participation.
- As part of enhanced exam security, flagged students may be required to temporarily surrender personal electronic devices (e.g., cell phones, smart watches, or other unauthorized items) to exam staff prior to the start of testing. Refusal to comply may result in denial of exam access or further disciplinary action.
- Break access is a conditional privilege. Students under increased monitoring may be subject to stricter break protocols, which could include limitations on break frequency or duration, escorted breaks, or additional check-in/check-out steps upon leaving and returning to the testing environment.

- Repeated or significant behavioral flags may result in further escalation, including formal review under institutional academic integrity policies. Patterns of concern may be considered alongside other evidence in determining potential violations.
- These measures are designed to protect the fairness and integrity of the testing environment for all students. All monitoring and follow-up actions are conducted in accordance with institutional academic integrity policies.
- By participating in examinations, students acknowledge and agree to comply with all exam security procedures, including any additional measures implemented as a result of monitored behavioral patterns.
- Students who report for examination in any course or clerkship declare themselves fit to sit for assessment. If a student is unable to take an exam due to illness or emergency, they should contact their Course or Clerkship Director prior to the start of the exam. Serious illness or injury not evaluated prior to an exam will not be accepted as an excuse for poor performance.

Assigned Seating

- Course and Clerkship Directors may implement assignment of seats.

Questions During Examinations

- Proctors will not answer questions regarding examination content.
- Proctors shall instruct the examinee to answer the question to the best of their ability with the information provided in the examination.
- When the testing platform provides an opportunity for students to comment on individual questions, students may use this resource to make comments.
- Challenges on specific examination questions must be submitted via the testing platform or in writing prior to the end of the scheduled examination session. Post-examination challenges are not accepted.

Accommodations

- Testing accommodations must be indicated on a Letter of Accommodation issued by the SHSU SSD.
- Making the necessary arrangements for testing accommodations is a responsibility shared by the student, the Course or Clerkship director, and SSD prior to the scheduled examination.

Failure to comply with test administration policies and procedures may result in a referral to the SPAP committee for possible disciplinary action.

Promotion, Remediation, Probation, Graduation, and Dismissal

Student Promotion and Academic Progress (SPAP) Committee

The SPAP committee shall maintain a continuing evaluation of the academic and professional progress of each student. Recommendations and options for actions include remediation, probation, dismissal, and promotion, including the recommendation for graduation. SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 (Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination (<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/910312%20Academic%20Probation%20and%20Suspension.pdf>) governs probation, suspension, dismissal, and termination of SHSU-COM students.

Academic Good Standing

Per SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 (Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination), students are considered to be in academic good standing when they have passed all courses/blocks/rotations in the curriculum to date and demonstrate competency in professionalism as defined by the American Association of Colleges of Osteopathic Medicine (AACOM).

For the purposes of co-curricular activities, leadership roles, travel, and student research, it is understood that first semester osteopathic medical students will not have generated an academic standing and will not be allowed to hold an officer position in an SHSU-COM sponsored student organization.

A student who is not in good academic standing may not participate in any extracurricular or co-curricular activities associated with SHSU. This includes, but is not limited to, leadership roles (student government, student organizations, student ambassadors, etc.) and program-related student travel. Students who are not in academic good standing are responsible for notifying the appropriate personnel of the change. Organization leadership of record may be found on OrgLINK: <https://shsu.campuslabs.com/engage/organizations?categories=16318>.

Students should be aware that failure to maintain academic good standing may affect financial aid eligibility and puts students at risk of dismissal from the program. Students actively engaged in ongoing research who are not in academic good standing must secure the permission of their research advisor and the SPAP committee to continue their research.

Remediation

A passing grade in each course and clerkship is required for the purposes of academic progression and eventual awarding of the DO degree. All failures must be successfully remediated to qualify for promotion and graduation.

As soon as a Subject to Remediation (SR) grade for the pre-clerkship course or the Fail (F) grade for the clerkship is official (i.e., reported to the SHSU Registrar) the student must meet with the course or clerkship director to arrange a plan for course remediation. Dates for remediation shall be determined and posted for students each semester. Repeat of a clerkship will be coordinated with the Departments of Clinical Education and Educational Affairs.

Successfully remediated pre-clerkship courses shall be reported as Passed with Remediation (PR) to the SHSU Registrar and will be the grade on the student transcript will change from SR to PR. Successfully remediated clerkships will be reported as Pass. Successful remediation of a clerkship does not remove the original failing grade from the student's record.

SPAP, Medical Student Affairs, and students shall be notified of the SR grade. If the academic calendar permits, students are required to meet with the remediation team and course director for support and resources.

For students repeating an academic year, the date of their withdrawal will be as soon as the COM Registrar receives a copy of the letter notifying the student of their unsuccessful remediation attempt and no later than the day preceding the subsequent semester, so that the student's percentage of program fee reimbursement will not be impacted. Any delay in the withdrawal date or continuation with registration for the subsequent semester due to academic grievances from the previous term may impact reimbursement. Students are encouraged to meet with SHSU Financial Aid if funds were received, and to contact Medical Student Affairs for information regarding procedures and resources. For students repeating an academic year, the expectation is that they shall pass all courses by the end of the repeated academic year. In most cases, failure of a course or clerkship while repeating an academic year shall result in dismissal.

Each single degree DO student shall complete the requirements for the DO degree within 150% of the standard time to achieve the degree (six (6) years following matriculation). The completion time of six (6) years includes time spent on leave of absence, pursuing research activities, etc. Students who are unable or deemed unlikely to be able to complete requirements within this time frame may be reviewed by the SPAP committee for further action.

Limitations

Students are allowed a maximum of two end-of-course retests (Remediation #1) per semester. Unused retest opportunities may not be carried over to another semester. Any retest beyond the maximum allowed shall automatically result in an SR grade for the course in place of the retest opportunity.

Students are allowed a maximum of three course remediations (Remediation #2) per academic year, with no more than two remediations per semester. Unused remediations may not be carried over to another semester or academic year. Any remediation beyond

the maximum allowed shall automatically result in a grade of F for the course in place of the remediation opportunity.

Professionalism

Professionalism is an integral part of the curriculum and is a component of every course and clerkship. Failure of the professionalism competency shall be considered sufficient reason to fail an entire course/clerkship, regardless of performance on assessments. The SPAP committee shall review students' professional behavior in and out of class and retains the right to invoke appropriate disciplinary measures, up to and including dismissal, for failure to adhere to standards of professionalism or ethical conduct. Please see the SHSU-COM Professionalism Policy

(<http://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academicaffairs/documents/com-policies>)

Probation

A student shall be placed on academic probation if a student fails any block/course or clerkship.

A student may also be placed on probation for professionalism or ethical concerns. The SPAP committee shall determine if and/or when a student should be removed from probation. A student will be removed from probation only after all deficiencies have been remediated, and the SPAP committee determines that the student meets all academic, professional, and ethical expectations. A student may remain on probation for longer than an academic year if concerns persist about their professional, ethical, or academic progress.

All students placed on probation for any reason will be notified in writing. The notification will include an indication of the minimum probationary period and the conditions necessary to successfully complete the probation.

While on probation, a student is expected to attend all classes and activities. Except for required electives in the curriculum, no electives are permitted while a student is on academic probation without the approval of the SPAP committee. Exceptions may be made for electives that do not interfere with the required curriculum or remedial work, such as a summer preceptorship. While on probation, students may not hold an elected office in student organizations or otherwise represent the COM or SHSU.

Students should be aware that the Texas Medical Board and other medical licensing boards may require disclosure of a student's probation status during medical school when applying for a license.

SHSU-COM Transcript

Academic Standing is noted on the transcript at the end of each term. This includes good standing and academic probation. Students who are placed on probation may view

academic standing online via their unofficial transcript, and they will receive a letter. Although a student may return to academic good standing and be removed from academic probation, the student's transcript will continue to reflect the status of academic probation for the applicable term(s).

Promotion and Graduation

The SPAP committee is responsible for promoting students and recommending candidates for graduation. To be promoted from one year to the next, students must satisfactorily complete all the required coursework, meet all financial obligations to the college, and exhibit professional conduct and ethical behavior. To be promoted to the clinical years, a student must satisfactorily complete all the requirements in the pre-clerkship curriculum in Years 1 and 2 and take the Comprehensive Osteopathic Medical Licensing Examination (COMLEX-USA) Level 1.

A passing grade in all required courses and clerkships must be achieved to receive the Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine (DO) degree. Passage of COMLEX-USA Level 1 and COMLEX-USA Level 2-CE is required for graduation.

Exception to Probation Terms

Students have the right to appeal decisions of the SPAP committee taken against a student for academic, professional, or ethical reasons, by filing a written appeal to the Dean within ten (10) business days of the date of notification. The appeal must include the student's basis for appeal. Specific procedures for dismissal or an academic failure are outlined below. Students may also appeal other adverse decisions such as probation, repeating a year, etc. The Dean shall consider these appeals on a case-by-case basis and may appoint an ad hoc committee to hear the appeal, if warranted, and shall make a decision after considering the recommendation of the ad hoc appeal committee. The decision of the Dean is final.

Dismissal and Appeals Process

A student who demonstrates academic deficiency, personal irresponsibility, or unprofessional or unethical behavior may be dismissed. A student may be evaluated at any time for continuation or dismissal. Students who demonstrate repeated marginal performance or failures on coursework or clerkships may be considered for dismissal.

Students wishing to reenter after being dismissed must make a formal application through the Admissions Committee. The Admissions Committee shall consider such reapplication and make its recommendation to the Dean. If the Dean's decision is favorable, the SPAP committee shall recommend to the Dean the curricular placement of applicants for readmission. The respective committees may request the re-applicant to provide any relevant information they deem necessary for their decision process. SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 (Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic->

[affairs/documents/aps/910312%20Academic%20Probation%20and%20Suspension.pdf](https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/910312%20Academic%20Probation%20and%20Suspension.pdf)) governs the dismissal and dismissal appeals processes.

Academic Honor Code

Academic Integrity

SHSU-COM “expects students to engage in all academic experiences both in and out of the classroom with honesty” SHSU Academic Policy Statement 810213 (Academic Honesty <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/810213%20Academic%20Honesty.pdf>). Additionally, the study of Osteopathic Medicine guides students to the provision of professional and compassionate patient care and inter-professional teamwork in addition to an understanding and application of Osteopathic Principles and Practices, and not simply the passage of examinations.

Academic Dishonesty

Academic honesty is defined in paragraph 5.3, Chapter VI, of the Rules and Regulations, Board of Regents, The Texas State University System, SHSU Academic Policy Statement 810213 (Academic Honesty <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/810213%20Academic%20Honesty.pdf>), and in the SHSU Student Code of Conduct and Discipline in the Student Guidelines published by the Dean of Students’ Office. Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, collusion, falsification of research data, and the abuse of resource materials on an examination or other academic work.

Individuals who violate TSUS and/or SHSU academic dishonesty policy are subject to disciplinary action, up to and including dismissal. Issues related to academic honesty, as defined in paragraph 5.3, Chapter VI, of The Texas State University System *Rules and Regulations* and SHSU Academic Policy Statement 810213 Academic Honesty, may be handled as a professionalism competency concern and referred to the COM Student Promotions and Academic Progress (SPAP) committee and governed by SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination. A student may not be promoted or graduated until an allegation of academic dishonesty has been resolved.

Academic Standing

Per SHSU Academic Policy Statement 910312 (Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination), SHSU-COM students are considered to be in academic good standing when they have passed all courses/blocks/rotations in the curriculum to date and demonstrate competency in professionalism as defined by the SHSU-COM Professionalism Policy and the American Association of Colleges of Osteopathic Medicine (AACOM).

Students on Academic Probation, including any period of remediation, and/or students with a professionalism, ethics, and/or academic dishonesty violation are not in academic good standing.

A student's academic probation continues until all course/block/rotation failures or professionalism concerns are successfully remediated. Probationary status is updated on the transcript following the subsequent semester; however, this status will still be reflected on the transcript for the semester(s) it was in effect. Students with a history of academic probation will be monitored and their performance reviewed by the SPAP committee on an annual basis for the remainder of their enrollment at SHSU-COM.

COMLEX-USA Examinations

All SHSU-COM students must pass COMLEX-USA Level 1 and Level 2-CE to receive a DO degree. The Dean or designee has the authority to set the eligibility of students to take COMLEX-USA examinations, and the SHSU-COM will determine the compulsory testing window for each Level. Scheduling to take COMLEX-USA examinations occurs through the NBOME portal. Students will be granted access to their NBOME portal during Year 1.

Please refer to nbome.org for the most up-to-date testing information. All expenses, including fees, travel, and lodging, related to taking COMLEX-USA examinations are the responsibility of students.

SHSU-COM COMLEX Academic Advancement Policy

In addition to the below content, please reference the SHSU-COM Grading and Exam Policy, found in SHSU-COM Academic Standards (<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/com-policies/SHSU-COM%20Grading%20and%20Exam%20Policy%20and%20Procedure.pdf>). Students who successfully complete all Year 2 courses are conditionally promoted to Year 3, pending a passing score on COMLEX-USA Level 1. Students must sit for the COMLEX-USA Level 1 examination prior to starting their first core clerkship rotation during the compulsory testing window. Failure of COMLEX-USA Level 1 may result in a delay of graduation and an extension of the academic schedule to complete all required rotations.

A SHSU-COM student who fails COMLEX-USA Level 1 examination on the first attempt must retake the COMLEX-USA Level 1 examination before starting the first core clerkship rotation. This will likely require the student to use their four-week vacation during their third year.

A SHSU-COM student who fails COMLEX-USA Level 1 examination on the second attempt:

- will be allowed to finish the current rotation;

- must meet with the SPAP Committee;
- may not resume clerkship rotations until achieving a passing score on COMLEX-USA Level 1; and
- will be directed to the NBOME website to assure that all current NBOME policies are understood and followed.

If a SHSU-COM student fails COMLEX-USA Level 1 examination on the third attempt, the SPAP Committee will meet to make a recommendation to the Dean.

A SHSU-COM student who fails the COMLEX-USA Level 2-CE examination on the first attempt:

- will be allowed to finish the current rotation;
- will be withdrawn from the next rotation;
- must retake the COMLEX-USA Level 2-CE examination after four weeks of academic reassignment to study for the second attempt, then resume with the subsequent rotation; and
- must use their four-week vacation rotation to fulfill the academic reassignment if it has not already been used.

A SHSU-COM student who fails the COMLEX-USA Level 2-CE on the second attempt:

- will be allowed to finish the current rotation;
- must meet with the SPAP Committee;
- will be withdrawn from the next rotation and may not resume clerkship rotations until achieving a passing score on COMLEX-USA Level 2-CE; and
- will be directed to the NBOME website to assure that all current NBOME policies are understood and followed.

Students withdrawn from rotations after a second failure on the COMLEX-USA Level 1 or Level 2-CE may have their graduation delayed and may be placed on academic probation.

The Texas Medical Board requires passage of each part of a licensure examination within three attempts (Board Rule §163.6). Students who become ineligible for a Texas Medical License may be dismissed from the SHSU-COM.

Student-Provided Technological Devices

Electronic devices include but are not limited to, mobile phones and smartphones, computers, tablets and other handheld devices, audio and video players, and recording devices. Although the use of electronic devices can enhance the teaching and learning experience, the absence of unnecessary distractions and interruptions is essential for an effective learning environment. Course Directors are responsible for establishing and managing electronic device policies, which may change depending on the scope and purpose of a session.

Graduation Requirements

A minimum of 45 months must elapse between the date of matriculation and graduation. Students must complete the program within 150% of the standard time (six years following matriculation).

Resignation From the Program

Students wishing to resign from the Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine program should, in accordance with Academic Policy Statement 990407 (Student Resignations), begin this process with the Registrar's Office representative located in the SHSU-COM building on the first floor.

Eligibility for a refund is based on guidelines governed by SHSU policy for refund of tuition and fees (<https://catalog.shsu.edu/graduate-and-professional/financial-information/refund-information/#resignations-withdrawals>) and applicable law, including Texas Education Code, Section 54.006. Students may review the relevant information in the graduate and professional catalog linked above, including the differences in refund schedules for various term lengths (i.e., up to 5 weeks, between 5 and 10 weeks, and 10 weeks or greater).

A resignation will not be allowed if a grade has been earned or a final has been taken. In general, a student will not be permitted to resign after the last class day of the first block of the semester (you may view your academic calendar at <https://www.shsu.edu/academics/colleges/osteopathic-medicine/academics/academic-calendar>). A request to resign after the census date may be considered if the student demonstrates extenuating circumstances as described in Academic Policy Statement 990407 (Student Resignations <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/990407%20Student%20Resignations.pdf>). Students wishing to make such a request should follow the procedure described in section 4, "Request to Resign After Deadline Based on Extenuating Circumstances".

RESEARCH & TRAVEL

SHSU-COM is dedicated to the advancement of evidence-based medicine. As such, an emphasis on research literacy and student scholarly activity has been embedded within the curriculum. Students participating in research may do so as either the lead student investigator or a co-investigator under the direction of a faculty principal investigator (PI).

Student Research Eligibility

Students wishing to conduct research in conjunction with SHSU faculty/staff or external institutions must be currently enrolled, in academic good standing, and have completed their first semester. Students not currently enrolled and on a break between semesters (e.g., summer/winter/spring break) may still participate in research endeavors if they are currently registered for the next sequence of classes and in academic good standing.

Research Ethics and Compliance

Students must comply with the requirements for ethical conduct in research as described in Academic Policy 920808 Misconduct in Academic Research and Scholarship (https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/920808%20Misconduct%20in%20Academic%20Research%20and%20Scholarship_2025.pdf). Students must complete appropriate research ethics training through the university-authorized CITI program and must complete any additional training (HIPAA, lab safety, biosafety) when appropriate. All research projects must have current approvals by the applicable compliance body (IRB, IBC, IACUC) or have been deemed exempt by those bodies before any research activities can take place. This applies to research at SHSU and at other institutions where SHSU-COM students may be involved.

All students engaged in research must have a faculty principal investigator (PI) for that research project. If that faculty PI is external to SHSU, students are strongly encouraged to discuss the project with the SHSU-COM Director of Research to assess compliance and potential affiliation agreements. Additionally, students should limit the number of research projects for which they serve as the lead student to no more than two concurrent projects.

Failure to receive and maintain appropriate research compliance may result in professionalism violations or disciplinary action. Students may contact the SHSU-COM Director of Research at COMResearch@shsu.edu for assistance with research compliance.

Research Funding

The Medical Summer Scholars Program (MSSP) provides stipend support to students that participate in an approved faculty led research program during the summer of their first year. Only OMS1 students are eligible to apply to this program.

The Student Intramural Grant provides up to \$5,000 in research support for student-initiated projects in teams of two or more students. Students must have received signed approval and support from an SHSU faculty on their grant proposal.

Student Travel and Travel Funding

If you plan to travel on behalf of SHSU-COM, you must email COMStudentTravel@shsu.edu to make the administration aware of your plans. If you want to apply for travel funding, you must follow the additional guidelines and steps outlined below. Note: Students who have been approved to travel by the SHSU-COM or SHSU should consult the official SHSU-COM attendance policy referenced in their syllabi and follow all guidelines prior to making travel arrangements.

To be considered for a travel award, the applicant must be an osteopathic medical student in academic good standing currently enrolled at SHSU-COM and must be traveling to present data-driven (i.e., not theoretical) research or to represent SHSU-COM in national student leadership roles and/or to engage in specific advocacy or other efforts sponsored by faculty such as DO Day, AAO Convocation, etc.

Regarding travel to present research, only the student who submits the research to the conference and is responsible for presenting the research is eligible for a research travel award. These funds are limited and are not guaranteed. Additional funding may be available through the Office of Research and Sponsored Programs (ORSP) and the Graduate School at SHSU. Students are encouraged to explore those options if internal funding is not available. Exceptional cases supported by the PI, including requests that exceed the limit of two research-related trips, will be reviewed by the COM Research Committee.

In cases in which a student is awarded travel support to present research and also receives direct financial travel support from the conference organization, those funds are expected to be applied to the expenses of the travel. Students will need to apply the external travel award toward reimbursing the COM for their travel expenses after COM-Research determines allowable deductions (e.g., food allowance, membership specific to conference, and non-covered transportation by SHSU-COM [e.g., mileage]).

Professional development, including leadership/specialty training, will not be considered for travel funding. If a proposed trip is for a student organization, the requestor should contact Student Affairs (com-sss@shsu.edu) to inquire about possible alternative funding opportunities.

Requests for travel awards can be initiated through the “Student Travel Request Form”: https://forms.office.com/pages/responsepage.aspx?id=2MtTsZKzREebOePNuGd_AM8MtRofuSNCv2FYtmgCsElUOUFHOU9MVDQ0NDMwQUxSMUoyNEgzNTg4TiQIQCN0PWcu&route=shorturl. Regarding travel to present research, the request should be made at the time of abstract submission to the conference, not after a notice of acceptance from the conference has been received. Travel to any foreign or international destination requires submission of the Student Travel Application at least sixty (60) days prior to departure to ensure full compliance with university policy. For the purposes of this requirement, “foreign travel” is defined as travel to any destination outside the fifty (50) contiguous United States. Travel awards may not be granted or used for any travel, activity, or event that would constitute or support conduct in violation of Texas Senate Bill 17.

The deadlines for travel requests during each term are listed below.

Travel During	Application Due
Fall Semester	Sept 9 th
Spring Semester	Jan 16 th
Summer Term	Apr 30 th

After eligibility is determined, the requestor will be notified regarding their status. Those requests that are awarded will receive a Student Travel Award Initiation Form. Travel awards will be limited to a maximum of one travel award per student per academic year. Students are limited to two research-related travel awards during their undergraduate medical education. Exceptions may be granted when travel is required of a student holding an Osteopathic Student Government Association leadership role or other eligible role as designated by SHSU-COM.

The maximum amount for each travel award is \$1,200. SHSU-COM follows the SHSU Student Travel Policy

<https://intranet.shsu.edu/intranet/policies/finop/travel/documents/FO-TR-08%20Student%20Travel.pdf>.

Students traveling on behalf of the SHSU-COM or SHSU are required to follow the student travel policies for approval to travel.

STUDENT SERVICES & RESOURCES

Physical and Mental Health Resources

All SHSU-COM students are encouraged to actively maintain their physical and mental health. Students are encouraged to continue healthy habits while in medical school, including regular exercise, adequate sleep, time with friends and/or family, and a healthy diet. SHSU-COM provides an array of programs that focus on proactive health and wellness prevention. It is important to avoid overuse of alcohol and abuse of prescription or illicit drugs. When acute or chronic physical or mental health services are needed, SHSU-COM provides supportive opportunities for students to seek services.

Students may seek treatment from a physician or medical practitioner of their own choice and at their own expense or may seek available services from the SHSU Student Health Center. The SHSU Student Health Center is a primary care outpatient clinic located on the Huntsville campus that generally provides services for routine illness or minor injury, immunizations, lab testing, and nurse visits. For more information regarding services and hours of operation please see the following link <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/student-health-center/>. Additional physical health and mental health services are available through community resources listed in your class's Teams channel.

Students away on clinical rotations who experience an emergency, such as needle stick or other immediate issues can be seen at the hospital emergency department where they are rotating.

Student Counseling Services

The SHSU Counseling Center <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/counseling-center/> provides individual, couples, or group therapy to SHSU-COM students who are currently enrolled and need help managing stress, anxiety, depression, or other issues. The SHSU Student Counseling Center also has multiple online self-help resources accessible on the university website.

TimelyCare <https://timelycare.com/SHSU/> is a virtual care option. Students can download the app and get access 24/7. All services are free and accessible for all students to utilize. Services include Talk Now, scheduled counseling, digital self-care, health coaching, and access to psychiatry referrals with consultation from Counseling Center for access code.

On-site counseling services are also available to COM students through SHSU-Physicians.

The Jack Staggs Community Counseling Clinic

<https://www.shsu.edu/academics/colleges/education/centers/jack-s-staggs-counseling-clinic> has two locations, one on the Huntsville campus and one at The Woodlands Center location. The clinic is a training facility for masters and doctoral level students who are enrolled in a counselor education program at SHSU. Counselor education faculty supervise all counseling sessions provided by counselors-in-training. The clinic offers counseling services to students and to the community. Services offered include adolescent counseling, couples, family, group, individual, play, and sand tray therapy.

Additional Resources and Support

- The Jed Foundation Helpful Resources for Students
<https://jedfoundation.org/ulifeline-transition/> (formerly ULifeline)
- Tri-County Behavioral Healthcare 24-hour crisis line: 1-800-659-6994
- National Suicide Prevention Lifeline: 1-800-273-8255
- LGBTQ National Hotline: 1-888-843-4564
- Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

For more information regarding mental health resources, be sure to check the Wellness Resources content area of your class Team in Microsoft Teams.

SHSU-COM and COCA prohibit the provision of health care services to students by faculty involved in their evaluations. Additionally, it is a violation of the SHSU-COM policy for students to request that faculty members provide medications or other treatments outside of a proper physician-patient relationship. Students on self-selected elective rotations, outside the purview of SHSU-COM, must plan for their health care needs at the rotation site independently.

Academic Resources and Support

Academic Support Services

The Office of Medical Student Affairs provides academic support and learning resources to enhance medical students' educational experiences and to help them achieve personal and academic goals. The following support services are provided to all students individually or in a group setting:

- Time management
- Stress management
- Learning preference awareness
- Test-taking strategies
- Organizational skills
- Interpersonal and communication skills
- Transition to professional school
- Preparation for licensure exams
- Study plans

Students experiencing attention or learning difficulties may be referred to Services for Students with Disabilities, who can advise them regarding testing, evaluation, and possible accommodations. Faculty may refer students for academic support services through the SHSU Early Alert System via Campus Connect. Students may schedule individual appointments as desired through Campus Connect. For more information about the process to receive accommodations for a qualifying disability, please visit <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/services-disabilities/>.

Peer Tutoring

The Office of Medical Student Affairs oversees the peer-tutoring program at SHSU-COM, which is available to all enrolled students at no cost. The program is designed to enhance student learning and promote academic excellence. Students may request tutoring services or be referred by their course directors, a faculty member, an advisor, or by members of the Office of the Dean or Educational Affairs. All peer tutors receive training. Tutoring availability is provided through Campus Connect.

Learning Communities

SHSU-COM has four learning communities that provide osteopathic medical students with a supportive environment for advising and mentoring. Each entering student is placed into one of the four learning communities created to foster relationships between students and faculty and to provide community service and team-building opportunities. Programming is student-driven and might focus on such topics as social networking, lifelong learning, peer mentoring, medical professionalism, ethics, educational life balance, and wellness. In addition, the Office of Medical Student Affairs assigns smaller groups of students within learning communities to faculty advisors who support their academic and professional growth.

Career Counseling

SHSU-COM provides students with career preparation and guidance to choose the specialty and practice that best suits their interests, talents, and abilities. In addition to the multi-layered support system provided through the Learning Communities, students are provided career assessments, residency preparation, and assistance with curriculum vitae, personal statements, mock interviews, and summer educational and research opportunities. For research, students may seek out a faculty mentor in their area of interest.

Financial Aid and Debt Management

Financial Aid

SHSU's Office of Financial Aid provides financial aid options that help students contribute toward their educational expenses through the completion of the [Free Application for Federal Student Aid \(FAFSA\)](#). Students who are interested in Financial

Aid will find more information about available types of financial aid, who is eligible to apply, how and when to apply, and other information at <https://www.shsu.edu/dept/financial-aid/>.

Debt Management

The SHSU Student Money Management Center (SMMC) is a financial outreach and educational program that focuses on debt management. SHSU-COM students are provided financial wellness programs that address budgeting, repayment, and financial planning. Students are also provided with a personal financial coach to discuss long-term financial planning or any other related questions. For more information, please visit <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/smmc/>.

Newton Gresham Library

The Newton Gresham Library serves the research needs of the SHSU Community and is located in Huntsville. The library holds over 1.3 million books, bound periodicals, government documents, and a variety of formats, including multimedia, digital collections, microforms, microfiche, phonograph records, videotape, and newspapers. Other groups of materials housed in the Newton Gresham Library include paperbacks for recreational reading, current periodical issues, new books, and a children's literature collection. A multimedia lab, music listening room, study carrels, a small lounge area furnished with vending machines, and a copy center, including a public fax machine, are provided for the convenience of students and faculty. Library holdings information may be electronically accessed through an online catalog from hundreds of library and campus computer workstations, as well as remotely via the Internet.

A team of professional librarians, support staff, and student assistants provide reference, interlibrary loan, circulation, acquisitions, and other library services to the faculty, staff, and students of SHSU, as well as to visiting scholars and off-campus users. Students at SHSU-COM have access to the library virtually or physically at both Conroe and Huntsville. For more information regarding hours of operation go to <https://library.shsu.edu/> or contact the onsite SHSU-COM librarian.

Student Organizations

Medical student organizations provide students with opportunities to participate and become knowledgeable about professional associations. For a complete list of SHSU-COM student organizations, visit [OrgLINK](#). The Osteopathic Student Government Association (OSGA) is comprised of elected officers who serve as student leadership representing the student body. The purpose of OSGA is to serve as the official voice of the student body for the SHSU-COM. It discusses topics or concerns of medical students and provides solutions and a plan of action for improvement and benefit for all.

Reasonable Accommodations and Disability Services

Reasonable Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

In accordance with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, and other applicable laws, the SHSU-COM provides reasonable accommodations for otherwise qualified students with verified physical, psychological, and/or learning disabilities. An accommodation may not be provided if it would result in the fundamental alteration of the SHSU-COM's programs, services, or activities, or if it would impose undue financial or administrative burdens on the SHSU-COM.

The intent of this policy is to provide each student with the opportunity to excel academically while creating an environment conducive to learning. In doing so, however, SHSU-COM must maintain the integrity of its curriculum and preserve those elements deemed essential to the acquisition of knowledge in all areas of osteopathic medicine, including the demonstration of basic skills required for the practice of osteopathic medicine. For example, technology-related accommodations may be made in certain areas for students with a qualifying disability, but a candidate must be able to perform in a reasonably independent manner.

All applicants receiving supplementary application material for admission will be asked to certify they have reviewed the SHSU-COM Technical Standards and the Participation in Osteopathic Manipulative Medicine Laboratories requirements. A panel of physicians will be utilized to assess student's ability to meet Technical Standards if/when needed.

Any student accepted to SHSU-COM who believes themselves to have a qualifying mental and/or physical disability requiring an accommodation will provide necessary information and supporting documentation to the SHSU SSD representative. It is the responsibility of the student to have an evaluation and tests, if any, administered and interpreted. Any charges for an evaluation or forwarding of documentation are the student's responsibility.

Process for Requesting Accommodations

Requests for accommodations are made by the student according to the procedures outlined here: <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/services-disabilities/menu-page-procedure-request-services>. Requests for accommodation may be submitted to SSD at any time during the academic year, but, once approved, accommodations do not apply retroactively. Requests for accommodations must be approved in writing by an SSD representative. All requests for accommodations due to a physical, psychological, or learning disability must contain appropriate documentation consistent with the SSD General Documentation Guidelines available at <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/services-disabilities/documentation-guidelines> and be directed to SSD.

Student Travel, Contingency Plan, and Housing

Students will be responsible for their own transportation to and from their clerkship sites. Students are not considered employees of SHSU-COM and are not insured for any accidents or mishaps that might occur during any traveling that is done as part of the clerkship program.

Students may be required to complete core rotations with at least one “away” clinical partner. It is the intention of the COM to have every student in their assigned clerkship region for the third and fourth years. However, if the site you are assigned does not have a specific core clerkship available within a certain block, the COM will work with you on identifying an alternate site. For students assigned to an alternate site for a core, surgery selective, medicine selective, or women’s health selective rotation that is beyond 75 miles from their assigned region, housing will be provided by Clinical Education. Students choosing electives outside of the SHSU-COM affiliated regions will be responsible for securing their own housing. If a student has a rotation that becomes unavailable for any reason before or during their block, the Office of Clinical Education and Assistant Dean for Clinical Affairs, if needed, shall work to find an appropriate substitute rotation for that student. Substitute rotations may be in their region or a different region. The Office of Clinical Education actively pursues more rotations than necessary to accommodate the student cohort, to ensure excess opportunities within each region.

Some of the clerkship sites offer limited housing. This includes apartments, houses, and/or rooms in the hospital. These opportunities are typically available on a first-come first-served basis and will be facilitated through the Office of Clinical Education. Students who choose to participate in an elective rotation outside of the SHSU-COM affiliated regions will be responsible for their own housing. If a student has concerns related to the provided housing, they should immediately contact their Regional Clinical Coordinator.

Behavioral Intervention Team (BIT)

A Behavioral Intervention Team (BIT) is a cross-institutional group that identifies early signs of potential disruptive behavior, self-harm, and violence towards others. This team follows an established protocol to support students, employees, and the SHSU community. When BIT receives a report about concerning or problematic behavior, the team assesses the best approach to support, intervene, and respond effectively. They then connect individuals with the appropriate resources and, if needed, assist with reintegration into the campus community. To submit a [behavioral intervention form](#), visit shsu.edu/doso.

ACADEMIC STANDARDS & STUDENT DEVELOPMENT

Professionalism

Professionalism is central to the ethos of both the practice of medicine and conduct of research and an expression of the SHSU-COM's commitment to patients and society. Professionalism is governed by the SHSU-COM Professionalism Policy (<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/com-policies/SHSU-COM%20Professionalism%20Policy%20and%20Procedure.pdf>). The environment of the SHSU-COM is conducive to the ongoing development of professional behaviors in osteopathic medical students, faculty, and staff at all locations and is one in which all individuals are treated with respect. This includes exposure to aspects of patient safety, cultural competency, academic honesty, and interprofessional collaborative practice. SHSU-COM is committed to maintaining an environment that is optimal for learning, teaching, conducting research, and providing clinical care. Professional behavior is expected of all students as they interact internally and externally as representatives of the SHSU-COM. SHSU-COM's professionalism expectations are in alignment with the American Osteopathic Association's Code of Ethics (<https://osteopathic.org/about/leadership/aoa-governance-documents/code-of-ethics/>).

This expectation of professionalism extends to all domains in which status as representatives of SHSU-COM is relevant. Students should ensure their social media and other online presence reflects respect for their patients, staff, faculty, peers, and the practice of medicine. Conduct that undermines the public's confidence in the profession of osteopathic medicine fails to meet this expectation. Failure to adhere to professional standards may result in dismissal from the program.

Students are expected to behave in a responsible and professional manner while functioning in course/class or clerkship rotations. Failure to adhere to applicable standards of practice shall be considered cause for dismissal from course/clerkship rotations or the program. For applicable standards of practice, see the AOA Rules and Guidelines on Physicians' Professional Conduct (<https://osteopathic.org/about/leadership/aoa-governance-documents/aoa-rules-and-guidelines-on-physicians-professional-conduct/>).

Peer Experiential Learning

Skills training sessions in the Clinical Medicine (CM) and Osteopathic Manipulative Medicine (OMM) courses require that students practice examinations and selected skills on peers, or other students who are role-playing as patients. Skills include, but are not limited to, communication, physical examinations, and osteopathic techniques.

Guidelines and requirements regarding peer experiential learning are in each CM and OMM course syllabus.

Provision of Medical Care

SHSU-COM faculty members or any health professional providing health services through a provider/patient relationship must recuse themselves from the academic assessment or promotion of the student receiving those services. Physicians and health-care providers employed by SHSU-COM with primary duties providing care at the SHSU Physicians Clinic may provide care to SHSU-COM students if they do not evaluate student performance.

Students may not state or imply that they are providing medical care or entering into a physician-patient relationship when practicing clinical skills, inside or outside of a classroom setting.

Immunization Requirements

The SHSU-COM immunization policy concerns the responsibility of SHSU-COM for the health and safety of its students and the community to prevent the spread of vaccine-preventable diseases. Additionally, this policy describes how SHSU-COM is obligated to meet the contractual requirements contained in affiliation agreements between the University and its clinical education healthcare partners. To facilitate these requirements, SHSU-COM requires certain immunizations for its students.

Applicants and enrolled students must receive certain immunizations and maintain up-to-date documentation of such immunizations for the duration of the program and in order to be in compliance with Centers for Disease Control and Prevention recommendations and Texas State law. Applicants or students who are not current on their immunizations or who do not maintain current documentation regarding the same may not be guaranteed admission, continued enrollment in the educational program or eligibility for graduation with the DO degree.

All persons accepted for admission to the SHSU-COM must provide documentation of current immunization and screening. Unless otherwise specified below, the following vaccinations and screening must be documented at the time of matriculation and maintained in current status while enrolled:

TETANUS/DIPHTHERIA/ACELLULAR PERTUSSIS: Documentation of one dose of Tdap vaccine. Td vaccine every ten years thereafter;

MEASLES (RUBEOLA): Documentation of two doses of measles or MMR vaccine, or a positive titer confirming immunity (must include a copy of the laboratory report); first dose must be on or after the first birthday and doses must be at least twenty-eight days apart;

MUMPS: Documentation of two doses of mumps or MMR vaccine, or a positive titer confirming immunity (must include a copy of the laboratory report); first dose must be on or after the first birthday and doses must be at least twenty-eight days apart;

RUBELLA: Documentation of one dose of rubella or MMR vaccine administered on or after the first birthday, or a positive titer confirming immunity (must include a copy of the laboratory report);

VARICELLA: Documentation of two doses of varicella vaccine given at least twenty-eight days apart, laboratory evidence of immunity, laboratory confirmation of disease (must include a copy of the laboratory report), or diagnosis or verification of a history of varicella or herpes zoster (shingles) by a healthcare provider;

HEPATITIS B: A complete hepatitis B vaccine series (3 doses of Engerix-B or Recombivax HB, or 2 doses of Heplisav-B) AND a positive antibody titer (quantitative hepatitis B surface antibody–lab report required). If the titer is negative or equivocal, receive one dose of the vaccine (as a booster) and repeat the titer 1 to 2 months later. If the second titer is negative or equivocal, finish the series and repeat the titer 1 to 2 months after the final dose. If the titer is still negative after a second vaccine series, test for HBsAg and total anti-HBc to determine HBV infection status.

MENINGOCOCCAL: All students under the age of twenty-two who are entering a public, private, or independent institution of higher education in Texas must provide documentation that they have had a meningococcal (bacterial meningitis) vaccine or “booster” dose during the five year period prior to but no later than ten days before the first day of the first semester they will enter that institution;

INFLUENZA: An influenza vaccine is required annually (Compliance is not required at point of matriculation, but is required annually thereafter); and

TUBERCULOSIS: Documentation of negative TB skin test (PPD) within two months of matriculation or, negative IGRA blood test (must include laboratory report), or if history of a positive TB test (IGRA or PPD), documentation of a negative chest X-ray within two months of enrollment (must send radiology report of chest X-ray).

Students may be exempted by means permitted within Texas and Federal Law. However, even if exempted, a student may be denied the opportunity to participate in training or patient care in certain health care facilities in accordance with the policies of those facilities. Enrolled students who cannot participate in clinical rotations due to an inability to fulfill the requirements of affiliated healthcare facilities available to provide approved clinical educational experiences cannot be guaranteed continued enrollment in the educational program or graduation with the DO degree.

All immunization records will be reviewed prior to matriculation and annually to determine compliance. Applicants or students who fail to comply with this policy may be

subject to withdrawal of an offer of acceptance or disciplinary action, up to and including dismissal.

The expenses related to immunizations are borne by the student. Immunization records will remain separate from the academic record.

SHSU-COM shall maintain processes to ensure medical student compliance with the SHSU-COM immunization policy for the health and safety of its students and the community to prevent the spread of vaccine-preventable diseases while complying with Texas State Law and SHSU-COM contractual requirements contained in affiliation agreements between the SHSU-COM and its clinical education healthcare partners.

Prior to matriculation, all applicants must provide documentation that they are up to date with all immunizations as required by the SHSU-COM Medical Student Immunization Policy. Further, all applicants will be required to formally acknowledge understanding of the SHSU-COM immunization policy to include the potential for noncompliance to result in dismissal or failure to graduate.

Annually, student immunization records will be reviewed to ensure that required immunizations remain up to date.

Students may request exemption for medical and/or religious reasons. This request should be initiated by contacting the Technical Standards subcommittee by emailing COM_SPAP@shsu.edu. Any supporting documentation of these reasons by medical and/or spiritual professionals must be submitted along with the exemption request. These requests will be considered on a case-by-case basis. Prior to consideration of the exemption request, the student will receive counseling of the anticipated impact on their clinical education opportunities and on their ability to meet graduation requirements. This counseling must be acknowledged by the student in writing prior to consideration of the exemption request.

Other requirements may be added for clerkship rotations. Students should comply with all vaccinations/testing as required by the site providing the preceptorship.

.

Background Checks and Drug Testing

Hospital and health care facilities have policies requiring drug testing and criminal background checks for employees, students, and volunteers. Some facilities provide that students who test positive for drugs, or who have certain types of information in their criminal background checks, are ineligible to train in that facility. Therefore, criminal background checks will be required of all students prior to first year enrollment and prior to clinical rotations. Additional background checks might be required by rotation sites as dictated by their human resource policies. Drug testing will be required of all students prior to clinical rotations.

Background Checks

Background checks will be facilitated through CastleBranch on behalf of SHSU-COM prior to orientation and the start of clinical rotations. Any violations found on background checks prior to the start of clinical rotations will be referred to the SHSU-COM Assistant Dean for Clinical Affairs.

Drug Testing

Drug testing will be facilitated through CastleBranch on behalf of SHSU-COM prior to the start of clinical rotations. Results of any routine drug test will be confidentially reported to the Dean. Notice of normal drug testing and background checks will be provided to the clinical facilities. Please refer to the clerkship manual for more details regarding drug screenings during clerkships.

Random drug testing may be performed at any time. Between matriculation and clerkships, students who test positive on a drug test will be referred to a physician not affiliated with the SHSU-COM for evaluation. The physician will be designated by the SHSU-COM and the student will pay for the evaluation. Students may not continue in classes or rotations at SHSU-COM until the physician evaluation has been completed and the student has been cleared by the evaluating physician to resume classes, and a negative drug screen has been returned. Results of this evaluation will be shared with the Dean. If a student refuses evaluation or consent to share the results of this evaluation, they will be subject to disciplinary procedures, including dismissal.

If treatment is recommended, the student will be allowed to seek treatment and remain enrolled as a student but must be cleared by an evaluating physician and have a negative drug screen prior to resuming classes. This may delay graduation or necessitate repeating a year or course. Continued monitoring after treatment or evaluation will be under the purview of the Texas Medical Association Physician Health and Rehabilitation Committee or private physician as outlined below and will not be reported to the Dean unless the impaired student refuses or is unresponsive to the appropriate treatment.

The use of illegal drugs or failure of a drug screen is considered grounds for dismissal. Any questions or concerns about routine drug testing may be shared confidentially with the Dean.

Health Insurance

All students enrolled at SHSU-COM are required to show proof of health insurance annually or at the time of coverage expiration. All students must maintain health insurance coverage throughout their enrollment at SHSU-COM. Students may obtain health insurance privately or through one of the SHSU student health insurance plans offered by Academic HealthPlans™, found at <https://shsu.myahpcare.com>. Dependent coverage is also available through the student health insurance plan. Dependent coverage

payment must be paid directly to Academic HealthPlans and may not be billed to the student's account.

Students are required to submit proof of health insurance through Academic HealthPlans for verification. Academic HealthPlans will verify students have insurance coverage meeting the minimum standards required by the SHSU-COM. Insurance coverage should also include coverage for an occupational injury, such as blood exposure, that might put the individual at risk for a bloodborne infection (i.e., hepatitis B, hepatitis C, HIV). It is important for students to realize that medical expenses for care provided by hospitals affiliated with the SHSU-COM, including laboratory procedures and emergency care, are the responsibility of the student and not the clinical site, SHSU-COM, or SHSU.

Needle Stick/Exposure

In the case of needle stick/exposure of SHSU-COM students to blood and/or bodily fluids:

1. Immediately wash the area with soap and water and then apply direct pressure to stop bleeding if needed.
2. If blood or a bodily fluid has come in contact with the skin, eyes, nose, or mouth, thoroughly flush the exposed area with saline or water for a minimum of 5 minutes. If available, use the closest wash station. Remove contact lenses from eye if necessary.
3. Bodily fluids that come into contact with intact skin are NOT considered exposures.
4. Identify the source patient's medical record number (MRN), physician, physician phone number, and pertinent health information.
5. Immediately report the incident to your preceptor or charge nurse at your current location. The charge nurse or other clinical staff member will supervise the testing of the source patient and complete any necessary steps required by the clinical site's exposure policy.
6. Immediately seek medical treatment in accordance with the clinical site's policy, or, if necessary, at the nearest emergency facility. If not covered by the site, payment of any treatment will be the student's responsibility and charged to the student's insurance. Students are not employees and should not be treated as such.
7. Students are to complete a Student Incident/Injury Report form and send a copy to SHSU-COM Clinical Affairs.
8. Students are to follow up with the healthcare providers at the SHSU Student Health Center following an exposure at 936-294-1805 or a provider of their choice. The providers at the SHSU Student Health Center will review any test or lab results they have been provided with the student. If necessary, the healthcare provider will refer the student to outside providers for further treatment.

The Associate Dean for Clinical Affairs or designee shall serve as a point of contact for incidents or injuries involving students on clerkship rotations. Please see the clerkship manual for more details.

Summer Preceptor Guidelines

If you are planning to do a summer preceptorship with an established program, you must contact Clinical Education at compreceptorships@shsu.edu and provide required information concerning the proposed preceptorship in order to allow sufficient time to complete any necessary affiliation agreements are often required and/or to address any applicable insurance requirements.

Malpractice Insurance Coverage Policy

Subject to applicable policy terms, conditions, and exclusions, SHSU-COM's professional malpractice insurance includes students as insureds while on all training assignments approved by the SHSU-COM. Students may participate in unique clinical opportunities outside of the regular curriculum only with prior written approval of the Assistant Dean for Clinical Affairs or Senior Associate Dean for Clinical Integration in consultation with the Dean. Students who arrange clinical rotations at their own discretion are not covered under this policy. All rotation sites must be reported to the professional liability carrier, and it is the responsibility of the student selecting rotations to provide that information to the Office of Clinical Education.

Dress Code

The SHSU-COM student dress code is designed to promote professionalism in the learning and work environment. Students who do not adhere to the dress code may be asked to leave a session to change. Repeat dress code violations will be reported by the appropriate Course Director and reviewed by the SPAP committee.

Students are expected to wear their ID badge at all times and dress in business casual attire unless a Course Director specifies otherwise in the syllabus. Students are expected to wear their white coat at all times unless directed otherwise (e.g., during examinations). Students are expected to be clean, well-groomed, and dressed in a manner appropriate to their responsibilities. Please note the dress code on SHSU-COM campus will be observed Monday through Friday from 8am-5pm.

General Guidelines

SHSU-COM will provide:

- Two (2) pairs of official SHSU-COM scrubs
- Two (2) official SHSU-COM student white coats
- One (1) ID badge/name tag

If replacements for scrubs or white coats are needed, students should contact Medical Student Affairs for purchasing information. A replacement ID Badge can be acquired through the Bearkat OneCard Office.

Recommended acceptable attire includes collared shirts, ties (optional), slacks, skirts, blouses, sweaters, and dresses. Dress shoes, low heels, or flats should be worn. Do not wear open-toed shoes, flip-flops, tennis shoes, or porous shoes. Clothing should allow for an appropriate range of movement and be appropriate for a business casual environment.

SHSU-COM students may not wear hats, jeans, shorts, flip-flops, and athletic wear including t-shirts. In all cases, hair and nails should be clean and neatly groomed, good oral and skin hygiene adhered to, and strong fragrances/perfumes avoided. Official SHSU-COM scrubs may be worn with an official SHSU-COM white coat and ID badge to lectures on days when students have labs that require scrubs.

Clinical Sites

During clinical clerkships, students will wear clean, white jackets identifying them as students with SHSU-COM and name tags and name badges provided by the clerkship facility. The student must dress in a manner that is fitting for a physician in the clinical setting (business casual). When students visit a clinical site, they should adhere to the dress code of that site. Dress code infractions at clinical sites will be reported to the appropriate Clerkship Director and repeat violations will be reviewed by the SPAP committee.

If students are on a service that requires scrubs, students will be required to wear scrubs provided by the clerkship facility or personal scrubs that meet the requirements of the facility. Do not take scrubs from the facility unless authorized to do so.

Course and Faculty Evaluations

Student evaluations of all courses, clerkships, and instructors who teach in the osteopathic medical school curriculum are an important means to monitor and obtain useful information for improving the medical education program. All responses collected remain confidential.

Completion of course and clerkship evaluations is a professional expectation for all students. Student comments should be constructive and professional in nature to ensure they will be taken seriously and lead to improvement. The use of confrontational language is not considered constructive or professional and only tends to diminish the credibility of the evaluation. With this understanding, all ratings and comments are welcome. Constructive comments about individual faculty are also welcome. Students are also encouraged to offer supporting comments on a course or clerkship that was a positive learning experience for them and made the curriculum stronger.

Students are required to complete online evaluations of each course/clerkship/instructor as assigned by the provided deadline.

Participation

The collaborative adult learning model requires students to participate and actively engage in the learning process. Participation is not the same as attendance. Participation requires students to be actively involved in the learning process. The contribution made by the student should be related to the course content, be relevant to the class discussion, and advance shared learning. Confidentiality in the learning experiences as part of the formal curriculum is expected and should be treated as such. Shared information should never be used in a way that would jeopardize a person or organization.

Reproduction of Materials

All lecture videos and other course materials are available only to SHSU-COM students affiliated with a course or clerkship. At no time may students repost any course materials or share them with people unaffiliated with the course without express written permission from the Course or Clerkship Director.

Compliance and Training

Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act

Please see Family Educational Rights & Privacy Act (FERPA)
<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/students/810806%20Student%20Educational%20Records.pdf>).

Secure Student Record Keeping

SHSU protects the security, confidentiality, and integrity of student records and maintains security measures to protect and back up data. SHSU complies with the Texas Administrative Code, Chapter 202, Subchapter B, Rule 202.20 and the Family Education Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) to ensure the security, confidentiality, and integrity of student records. The University's Academic Policy 810806 (Student Educational Records <https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/documents/aps/students/810806%20Student%20Educational%20Records.pdf>) is established to assure FERPA compliance and designates types, locations, and custodians of various student records. This policy also provides guidelines for the printing of hard copy student academic records. The University has established an Information Security Program that provides direction for managing and protecting the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of SHSU information technology resources.

Title IX

Please see SHSU ACADEMIC REQUIREMENTS AND POLICIES.

All new SHSU-COM students are required to complete Title IX training. Students are expected to abide by the rules and regulations outlined in this training. Any student wishing to report a Title IX incident should follow the procedures outlined on the SHSU Office of Title IX & Discrimination Resolution website <https://www.shsu.edu/titleix/>.

Specialized Training

SHSU-COM students receive Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA), Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA), and Bloodborne Pathogen training during their SHSU-COM orientation. Students are required to maintain their training and update any required documents in CastleBranch. Training certificates will be kept on file and available for verification via the Division of Educational Affairs and the document repository in CastleBranch. Some sites might have policies that require students to update certificates prior to rotations.

Students wishing to engage in academic research outside of a course are required to complete all trainings required for ethics and/or biosafety. These trainings are offered through the Collaborative Institutional training Initiative (CITI). Instructions for completing those trainings can be found through the Compliance division of the SHSU Office of Research and Sponsored Programs (ORSP): <https://www.shsu.edu/offices-departments/research-sponsored-programs/research-compliance>. Additional training regarding laboratory specific safety and procedures will be required when appropriate. Questions regarding training and compliance should be directed toward the faculty PI and/or the SHSU-COM Director of Research at COMresearch@shsu.edu. See also “Research & Funding.”

SHSU ACADEMIC REQUIREMENTS AND POLICIES

For a comprehensive list of SHSU's graduate student academic requirements and policies, go to the online version of the university's [Graduate and Professional Catalog](http://shsu.edu/academics/catalog/) (<http://shsu.edu/academics/catalog/>) and the Division of Academic Affairs' [Policies and Procedures](https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/policies.html) (<https://intranet.shsu.edu/dept/academic-affairs/policies.html>).

Academic Good Standing

Academic Grievance Procedures for Students

Academic Honesty

Academic Probation, Suspension, Dismissal, and Termination

Course Load

Courses and Grades Applied to Degrees and Certificates

Graduate Academic Program Admission and Completion Requirements

Leave of Absence

Resignation

Student Code of Conduct

Student Grievance Procedures

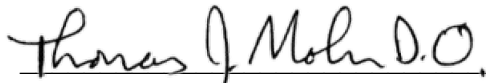
Student Absences on Religious Holy Days

Students with Disabilities

Title IX and Discrimination

Student Privacy Information (FERPA)

APPROVED BY:



Thomas Mohr, DO

Vice President for Medical Affairs

Dean of College of Osteopathic Medicine

July 22, 2026

Date

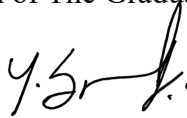


Jennifer Bunn, PhD

Dean of The Graduate and Professional School

August 5, 2026

Date



Sumanth Yenduri, PhD

Provost and Senior Vice President for Academic Affairs

August 11, 2026

Date